

THE MEDIA BUSINESS: Publishing; Smaller books can be tactile, and even sensual, hinting at delights, and profits, ahead.

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March 15, 1993



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THE Itty Bitty Book Light now has the perfect companion: the itty bitty book. Inspired by the recent success of several books that have come out in a smaller, more compact format, publishers are now packaging more books, particularly novels, in trimmer size and are increasingly regarding this once-rare design as a standard option.

And customers are buying them. Two small-size novels are on the New York Times best-seller list next Sunday: "The Bridges of Madison County" (Warner) by Robert James Waller, in the No. 2 slot, which has been on the list for 32 weeks, much of that time in the No. 1 position, and "Einstein's Dreams" (Pantheon) by Alan Lightman, the No. 10 book.

Several other best-seller lists around the country include another book of this size, "Like Water for Chocolate" (Doubleday) by Laura Esquivel.

Publishers and booksellers say there are good reasons for the trend. Although the sizes vary by house, the average book tends to be about 9 3/8 inches by 6 1/8 inches, while the smaller books are about 7 3/4 inches by 4 3/4 inches. Books in the smaller sizes are more portable, easier to finish, usually cheaper -- they range from about \$15 to \$18, compared with \$23 to \$25 for most novels -- and they add a tactile, even a sensual element, to the experience of reading.

"Somehow, the size draws you into the book," said Stephen Rubin, president and publisher of Doubleday. "It's a cuddly size, and it is becoming to the literary novel what foil and embossing have been to the commercial novel, a signal of a kind of book."

Most people in publishing trace the current wave of small books to Alfred A. Knopf's spring 1991 publication of "Damage," Josephine Hart's erotic novel about the obsessive and tragic affair between a member of the British Parliament and his son's fiancée. The volume was small and exquisitely designed to look somewhat like a backgammon board, visually implying the book's theme that love and attraction can be a dangerous game.

Sonny Mehta, the president and editor in chief of Knopf, who also oversees Pantheon, is widely praised in the industry for appreciating the value of a book's visual effect and for assembling a design staff that regularly produces memorable covers.

" 'Damage' is certainly the granddaddy of these books," said Laurence J. Kirshbaum, president of Warner Books. "You have to give Sonny a lot of credit for realizing that size is a very important element in a book's design, equally as important as the cover art. It's a tremendous marketing device that in a sense makes these books seem bigger by making them physically smaller."

Mr. Mehta said he would "love to take credit" for the trend "but really can't." He said his library shelves hold many slim small volumes published decades ago, including a favorite copy of "Plutarch's Lives" and a set of Jane Austen novels printed in the 1920's.

A number of other small books have recently been released or are soon to be, including: "Kitchen" (Grove Press) by Banana Yoshimoto, "Written on the Body" (Knopf) by Jeanette Winterson, "A Mother's Love" (Nan A. Talese/Doubleday) by Mary Morris and "Vertigo Park and Other Tall Tales" (Knopf) by Mark O'Donnell.

Publishers and booksellers say that the smaller size should not be used indiscriminately, adding that this format should reflect the contents of the book rather than being used only as a marketing ploy or it will cease to be effective.

Three of the current best-selling small books demonstrate the successful chemistry of size and content. "The Bridges of Madison County" is about a four-day love affair between an Iowa farm wife and a photographer passing through town, and the small size of the book seems to fit this intimate story.

"Einstein's Dreams" imagines the physicist pondering the nature of time as he works as a patent clerk, and the fantasies in the book seem suited to a whimsical size.

"Like Water for Chocolate," which is subtitled "A Novel in Monthly Installments With Recipes, Romances and Home Remedies," is the story of a doomed love affair, and each chapter begins with a recipe. Given the size, the volume both reads and feels like part-diary, part-recipe book.

"It can be a wonderful device for the right book," said Elaine Petrocelli, owner of Book Passage, a store in Corte Madera, Calif. "But I pray that publishers don't kill these kinds of books by overdoing it."

Having discovered, or rediscovered the appeal of the small book, publishers say they have begun to experiment with other odd sizes in an effort to find unusual packaging that will entice readers to at least flip through the pages.

Knopf and Pantheon lead the field in this design innovation. "The Secret History" (Knopf) by Donna Tartt, a best seller last fall, had several design elements that made it stand out, including a celluloid jacket with some of the cover type and art printed on it. It was also slightly narrower than standard, enough to make the book stand out to browsers.

"Einstein's Dreams" is squatter and smaller than the other current small books. And in May, Pantheon is to publish "Shadow Play" by Frances Fyfield, a crime thriller about a man who stalks little girls, which was designed a tad narrower and shorter to emphasize the elongated shadows that appear on the cover.

Another innovator is Chronicle Books, a San Francisco-based publishing house that specializes, appropriately, in books about design. Chronicle has had two slim, almost square-shaped books on The Times's fiction list for many weeks, both by Nick Bantock, about a continuing epistolary romance between an artist and a secret admirer: "Griffin & Sabine," No. 8 on Sunday, and "Sabine's Notebook," which was No. 11 last week.

As Mr. Mehta said: "The biggest challenge to publishers is getting customers who are faced with a multiplicity of choice to stop for a moment. Format may do that, but then it is up to the book itself to hold them there."

A version of this article appears in print on , Section D, Page 6 of the National edition with the headline: THE MEDIA BUSINESS: Publishing; Smaller books can be tactile, and even sensual, hinting at delights, and profits, ahead.